
Participatory design	Yes	Participants are providing suggestions and solutions in their responses. If those include code contributions, the Individual Contributor License Agreement (ICLA) question must also be shown.
Interviews and focus groups	Maybe	If you anticipate the participant will provide suggestions or solutions in their response, the IP Assignment must be shown.
Longitudinal studies and focus groups above.	Maybe	Refer to Interviews
Surveys w/ open-ended questions and focus groups above.	Maybe	Refer to Interviews
Solution validation and focus groups above.	Maybe	Refer to Interviews
Card sorting and Tree testing yield suggestions or solutions.	No	Responses will not
Diary studies yield suggestions or solutions.	No	Responses will not
Category Maturity Scorecarding & UX Scorecards	No	Responses will not yield suggestions or solutions.
Surveys (multiple choice, ranking, scoring)	No	Responses will not yield suggestions or solutions.

Who is responsible for determining if the IP Assignment needs to be shown?

The research project DRI is responsible in determining if the IP Assignment needs to be shown. This is because they have the closest knowledge of the research questions and what desired output of the research project. If the research project DRI is unsure whether the IP Assignment needs to be shown, they can always reach out to legal to confirm.

How we show the IP Assignment

The research tool being used (for example Qualtrics, UserTesting, Respondent) determines how the IP Assignment can be shown. Choose one of the two following options, but in either case display the IP Assignment at the start of the survey, screener, or email.

1. A statement - This is a statement which requires no user action. The act of participating in the research activity constitutes assent to the IP Assignment.

- By participating in this, and any future, research activities with GitLab, you acknowledge that GitLab Inc. will retain all intellectual property rights in any suggestions, ideas, enhancement requests, feedback, or other recommendations you provide which are hereby

assigned to GitLab Inc.

1. A question - This is a question which requires the participant to choose 'Yes' to indicate their acceptance of the IP Assignment. If they choose 'Yes', they will continue with the research; if they choose 'No', they cannot take part.

- I agree that by participating in this, and any future, research activities with GitLab, GitLab Inc. will retain all intellectual property rights in any suggestions, ideas, enhancement requests, feedback, or other recommendations I provide which are hereby assigned to GitLab Inc.

☐ Yes

☐ No

Frequently Asked Questions

- Question: My research study will result in code contributions from my participants. What's the ICLA question I need to ask?

- Answer: Below is the exact question to ask. Note the active link in the statement.

- Any code contributions you make as part of your participation in this research activity are made subject to GitLab's Individual Contributor License Agreement.

☐ I accept the terms of GitLab's Individual Contributor License Agreement.

☐ I do not accept the terms of GitLab's Individual Contributor License Agreement.

- Question: I'm planning to run a blind study. Do I need to show the IP Assignment?

- Answer: If you anticipate the participant in the blind study will provide suggestions or solutions in their response, the IP Assignment must be shown. This requirement may prevent a blind study from taking place. If the blind study is run by a third party vendor, it's likely that vendor will include suitable IP assignments in (i) the end user terms of service between the vendor and their research panel participants; and (ii) the vendor agreement between the vendor and GitLab. Reach out to legal to confirm suitable IP assignments are in place for a given vendor.

- Question: Do we treat non-GitLab users any differently?

- Answer: No. Same guidelines apply.

- Question: If the participants are anonymous, are there any special considerations?

- Answer: No. Same guidelines apply.

- Question: Are these IP Assignment options included in the Qualtrics survey question library?

- Answer: Yes. To access the IP Assignment options from within your Qualtrics survey, follow these steps: (1) create a survey question, (2) in the "..." select replace from library, (3) select the "UX Research & Product" library, (4) select "Question Library", (5) select the IP Assignment option that you want to use: "IP Statement", "IP Assignment Question", or "Individual Contributor License Agreement (ICLA)", and (6) select "Import"

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research-coordination/ndas.md

If we share information that is Confidential within a UX research study, as described in the

GitLab Code of Business Conduct and Ethics, we may ask research participants to sign a Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA). Typically, however, we don't ask participants to sign an NDA. A best practice is to check with your Product Manager to see if an NDA is needed for your research. NDAs must be signed by both the participant AND a member of GitLab's legal team.

If one is needed, reach out to @asmolinski2 and let him know. He will set up a spreadsheet to document the participants who need to sign an NDA. He will create the NDA and send it to the participants. It is the responsibility of the person conducting the research to check the status of their participant's NDA prior to conducting their session. If an NDA is not signed by all parties, the session will need to be rescheduled.

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research-coordination/recruitment-methods.md

UX research operations coordinators have several resources to recruit from. Learn more about each source and anticipated timelines.

Recruitment methods

1. Respondent.io: is a participant recruitment service that is a good choice for studies aimed at software professionals who may or may not be GitLab users. This has been a good source to find security professionals and some other harder-to-reach participants. Respondent is also a great choice for when you need users quickly.

- Respondent.io is one of the fastest options depending on criteria and typically participants start qualifying within a few hours.

1. UserTesting.com: is an unmoderated usability testing platform. We can use their panel to recruit users for usability tests through their platform.

- Participants typically start qualifying within a few hours depending on criteria.

1. Social outreach: Social posts may go out on GitLab's brand channels. The UX Research Operations Coordinator uses the Social Request issue template in the Corporate Marketing project to request this type of post. The DRI who opened the recruitment request may also be encouraged by the UX Research Operations Coordinator to handle opening the social request issue. This is a good choice for studies primarily aimed at GitLab users. Product Managers, Product Designers, and other teammates are highly encouraged to help promote their studies through their networks.

- Allow 1-2 weeks for these requests to go live.

1. Direct Sourcing: We can utilize LinkedIn to approach and source potential participants. Anyone at GitLab is able to request a LinkedIn Recruiter license. This Unfiltered video and slide deck provide an overview on how to use LinkedIn Recruiter to source participants for your study. Please note that your LinkedIn Recruiter seat is likely limited to sending only 200 InMails your first week. If you go over this amount, your account will be disabled for a week. After the first week, you can send up to 1000 InMails a day. If you go over this limit, your account will be disabled for a day.

- Allow 2 weeks minimum as this is the most time consuming recruitment method.

1. Docs site banner: We can occasionally use a banner on the Docs site to promote larger surveys. There are some biases that should be considered when sampling by this method.

- The docs team can choose not to allow your request. Typically it takes 1 week to get this up and running.

1. In-product banner or prompt: In some rare occasions, traditional recruitment methods may not

be effective in finding the right participants at the right moment in time. An example of this may be capturing user sentiment on an experience, in real time. It's important to note that this method can negatively impact the user experience and workflows of our users, so we need to be mindful when, where, and how often this method is used. In general, this is a rarely used method since other recruitment methods are effective in identifying the right participants for our research needs. If an in-product banner or prompt is to be used, please follow the approval process.

1. Marketo: The majority of recruitment requests will be fielded through Marketo when looking for SaaS and Self-Managed users. Marketo is a tool primarily used by the Marketing Operations team to send emails out to our customer base. By using Marketo we are ensuring compliance in our outreach to participants and allowing a single source of opt-out from our communications.

- Allow 2 weeks for responses to come in. You will likely need 3-4 email sends to reach your target number of responses.

1. Data Warehouse: Occasionally we may need to use the DataWarehouse for requests that are unsuccessful with Marketo. There are only SaaS users in the DataWarehouse and there's no access to Self-Managed users.

- It will take a few days to generate the list of users based on workload if a query doesn't already exist for your target audience. Once the query is created, allow 2 weeks and multiple email sends to fill the request.

GDPR and CAN-SPAM requirements

At GitLab, when we communicate with our research study participants, we take GDPR and CAN-SPAM requirements seriously.

- Anyone can submit a personal data request to see which lists they are subscribed to, and be removed from any and all of them. The UX Research Operations Coordinator routinely processes these requests by searching for the contact in the UX research Qualtrics directory. If the contact is not present, the coordinator comments in the issue to document. If the contact is present in the directory, the coordinator deletes the contact, then confirms in the issue that the contact has been removed.

- Every email sent to the research panel members contains an unsubscribe link. When a recipient clicks the link, Qualtrics automatically confirms that they have been unsubscribed from the mailing list.

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research-coordination/reops-procurement.md

When working with procurement on onboarding new tools, payments of POs, contract renewals etc. these are best practices to follow.

Best practices

- Open a ReOps tooling issue and add it to the ReOps tracker

- Provide updates in the issue

- See this example

- Determine if it's a request for procurement or accounts payable. For new tooling, vendors, and invoices you will need to go through the procurement process. For re-ups or payments on existings contracts you need to work with accounts payable.

- Procurement: Follow the steps outlined in procurement process
- Accounts payable: Email accounts payable (AP@gitlab.com) directly with all necessary information
- Check in every 2 days to ensure the process is moving
- If the process is stuck on a step, reach out to the procurement or accountspayable Slack channel to identify who you can reach out to directly.
- Maintain communication and provide proactive updates with the vendor
- Provide updates and screenshots of email chains in the issue comments
- See this issue for an example
- Get confirmation from the vendor that funds were received
- Provide a screenshot in the issue comments

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research-coordination/research-coordinator-fill-in.md

There are times when you will play the role of UX Research Operations Coordinator. This page details all of the 'behind the scenes' steps needed to execute a successful recruit from start to finish. Are you interested in how to work with our UX Research Operations Coordinator? If so, you can find that information here.

The Process

Step 1 - Familiarize yourself and communicate to others

- The UX Research Operations Coordinator will open a coverage issue in the UX Research project listing out the priority of projects, what needs to be done, and link to any resources that may be helpful while they are unavailable.
- The UX Research Operations Coordinator will @ mention you on any ongoing recruitment issues that you need to pick up. They will provide you with a clear description of the status of the issue and what needs to be completed.
- The UX Research Operations Coordinator will assign you to any of these ongoing issues so you can easily track them.
- The UX Research Operations Coordinator will also share the Open Recruitment Projects sheet with you and tag you on projects that require assistance.
- Introduce yourself, in the product and ux Slack channels, as the recruitment point of contact for the next X days and/or weeks.
 - If people attempt to raise recruiting requests in Slack, remind them to create a recruiting request issue and assign it to you for tracking and visibility purposes.
 - Remind them an issue has been handed off to you once you confirm the handoff in a comment.
- Be sure to join the uxreops Slack channel for easier coordination if there is more than one person covering for the UX Research Operations Coordinator.
- If the UX Research Operations Coordinator is going to be unavailable for more than 7 consecutive business days they will open an MR on the Research Recruiting & Incentive Request Issue Template to make sure whoever is covering for them is auto-assigned to newly opened issues.

Step 2 - Dealing with new recruiting requests

Note: Remember to update the issue with every action you take and its results.

- Assess the desired timeline. Our SLA for recruiting is 2 weeks minimum depending on the criteria, although some requests are fulfilled much more quickly.
- Keep in mind:
 - If they say they want to speak with users "in the next couple of days," communicate that recruiting may take up to two weeks.
 - The more specific the recruiting criteria (the more qualifications they have or the greater number of respondents they need) the harder it will be to recruit and the longer it will take.
 - Example: A request for five software developers who have used our global search feature would be very straightforward and quick to recruit for. A request for 100 self-managed admins who recently upgraded to Ultimate would be more difficult and time-consuming to recruit for.
- Assess the recruiting criteria to ensure you fully understand who they are looking to research. Is any of the criteria ambiguous to you?
 - Ask questions until you can distill the criteria down to a few bullet points, for example:
 - DevOps engineers
 - Responsible for configuring environments for their team
 - At large organizations (500+ people)
 - GitLab or non-GitLab users
- Review the Qualtrics screener
 - Ascertain if the current questions will provide the needed screening criteria. If not, provide feedback in the recruitment issue and suggest edits until the screener directly maps to their stated criteria.
 - Don't forget to reach out to the UX researcher for assistance. They help the PM and/or Product Designer put together the screener in Qualtrics.
 - The person requesting the research is responsible for creating the screener in Qualtrics and adding you as a contributor.

Step 3 - Choose the best recruiting channel from these options

- Data warehouse contacts
 - Requires editor access & SQL knowledge
 - Contains GitLab SaaS user information.
 - Can be used to identify respondents for surveys.
 - Pull contacts of GitLab SaaS users and then follow the usual process in Qualtrics.
- Respondent.io:
 - Great for quick turnarounds, or when participants don't necessarily need to be GitLab users.
 - How to use it:
 - Log into Respondent and build and launch the campaign, using the screener from the person conducting the research.
 - Take care to double check your criteria and set the correct questions to "disqualify" participants. For example, you can specify that you only want Jira users by setting 'Jira' as a 'must select' response in the relevant question. This will automatically disqualify anyone who chooses another response. This saves you time by reducing the volume of screener responses you need to comb through. It also helps non-researchers easily see who is qualified to take part in the study.
- UserTesting.com
 - Good for unmoderated usability tests
 - We can leverage their panel to recruit technical users
- Using Team members to socialize requests:

- How to use it:
 - Post in Slack channels like ux, product, and whatshappeningatgitlab . Include a concise call to action, due date, and share the link that you want people to post.
- Direct outreach on LinkedIn:
 - How to use it:
 - You can search for the criteria you are looking for and use inMail credits to invite them.
 - If you do not have a Recruiter License, you will need to open an access request.
 - Watch this video for how to get started
- Marketing newsletter:
 - Note: Reserve this for critical studies, like the SUS.
 - The newsletter is sent on the 10th and 25th of each month.
 - How to use it:
 - Submit a request for the survey to be included in the newsletter. Here is an example issue.
 - Search the Digital Marketing project for newsletter 2020 and select the issue for your target date. If an issue is not open yet, find the most recent issue and comment on it to ask about a request for the next newsletter. Make sure to @ mention the person who opened that issue.
- Docs site banner:
 - We can occasionally use a banner on the Docs site to promote larger surveys. It is a lightweight way to quickly fulfill surveys that otherwise would be restricted to panels or the data warehouse.
 - There are some biases that should be considered when sampling by this method. (People using the Docs site are usually looking for information on a potential road block they have.)
 - The docs team can choose not to allow your request. Typically it takes 1 week to get this up and running

Step 4 - Paying participants

- Participants are paid differently, depending on the recruiting channel you use
 - Respondent.io
 - Pay users within the Respondent platform.
 - There should be credits loaded into the platform. Click the "approve" button to pay people who have attended sessions.
 - If there are sessions where participants have not been marked "attended," please remind the interviewer to do so ASAP, or to verify that they were a no-show. This should be done in a timely manner, so our platform profile can retain a good standing.
 - Tremendous
 - This method is currently being used for paying all UX Research participants that do not come through Respondent.io.
 - Access to the platform is restricted & an AR may need to be opened for the UX Researcher covering.
 - Select Send Rewards.
 - Navigate to the campaign you want to process the incentives under.
 - Input the participants email address and first name, as well as the reward value in USD. Tremndous will automatically offer the participants the relevant reward based on their location.
 - Click Add Recipient. You will have the option to add more as required or you can also upload a csv.

- Continue to the payment screen.
- On the payment screen select Pay with Credit Balance, and then click process.
- Your participants should receive their incentive same day, but allow up to 48 hours for processing.

Transferring back to the UX Research Operations Coordinator

- You made it! The UX Research Operations Coordinator is back in action and ready to take over.
- Assign the UX Research Operations Coordinator any recruiting issues that are still open.
- @ them in a comment and provide an update on the status of the issue and what still needs to be done.
- Update the coverage issue the day before the UX Research Operations Coordinator returns as not everyone is based in the same timezone and they may start their workday before yours.
- If needed, the UX Research Operations Coordinator will open a new MR to remove the UX Researcher from being automatically assigned to new research recruitment requests.

Resources

- How the UX Research Team Operates
- Recruitment case study

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research-coordination/participation-gratuities/index.md

As a small token of thanks (and to ensure a higher participation/completion rate) we send gifts to research participants for partaking in UX research studies. These can be requested by opening an issue in the UX research project if you do not already have a recruitment issue open.

Study Qualification

To determine if your study qualifies for incentives distribution through the ReOps team we use the following criteria:

- A project that is oriented on researching/learning about GitLab, proposed new features, or evaluating GitLab
- Has an associated UXR (not a requirement but something we look for)
 - If there is no associated Research and/or ReOps issue - reach out to the Research Operations team through Slack on the uxresearchoperations channel to see if we can process the gratuities for you. We request that you have approval before offering an incentive to your participants.

If you are unsure as to whether your study qualifies for incentives, reach out in the uxresearchoperations prior to conducting your project to seek approval. We are happy to process incentives for other departments on a case-by-case basis.

Incentive Participation Limits & Considerations

- There are some cases outside of country restrictions where we cannot provide a gratuity for

participants.

Such as:

- The participant has received \$599 (USD) in one calendar year.
 - The participant has indicated that they are a government or non-profit employee.
 - The participant has indicated that they are unable to receive an incentive based on company policy.
- In these cases, the participant can still take part as long as you have confirmation that they are fine to proceed without an incentive. Our core screener questions aim to capture this information.

Gratuity Recommendations

- User interviews or usability testing research: \$60 (or equivalent currency) Tremendous gift card per 30 minutes. In the table below is a quick view of the incentives based on different interview lengths.

Interview Length	Incentive
-----	-----
30 Minutes	\$60
45 Minutes	\$90
60 Minutes	\$120
75 Minutes	\$150
90 Minutes	\$180
2 Hours	\$240

- Surveys, card sorts, and tree tests will often have a Promotion Game attached e.g. Opportunity to win 1 of 3 \$30 (or equivalent currency) Tremendous Gift cards. However, this is not always the case and should always be confirmed on your recruitment issue. On occasion our longer surveys are incentivized per complete. This must be approved by the Senior UX Research Operations Coordinator or UX Research Manager.

If you are planning to recruit users through a promotional game or contest (e.g., Opportunity to win 1 of 3 \$30 (or equivalent currency) Tremendous Gift cards), please review the following information in the handbook and consult with legal where required. For information on contacting legal, please refer to how to reach us in the Legal Team handbook page. Engaging legal for approval and creating an incentive request must be completed before conducting research involving promotional games or contests.

Note if you need to cancel or reschedule the session, you will still need to process the gratuities in some cases.

Notice Period Given	% of Incentive To Pay Out
-----	-----
<= 24 hours ahead of the session	100%
<= 36 hours ahead of the session	50%
> 36 hours ahead of the session	0%

For Cancellation or Rescheduling best practice, see the Resources for Research DRIs page

Fulfillment

Requests for thank you gifts should be fulfilled at least twice per week so that users receive their gift promptly after participating in research. It's important to maintain a customer first mindset when interacting with participants - receiving their gift is the end of the research cycle and another touchpoint in their relationship with GitLab. Participants who take part through Respondent or other 3rd party tools, will have their incentives processed the next business day by the UX Research Operations Coordinator - only if the UX Researcher on the project has marked the participants as attended.

Tremendous

Tremendous is the incentive distributor that we use. These incentives are sent via RallyUXR, our research CRM platform so that we can keep all incentives in one place for tracking and budgeting purposes.

Tremendous allows us to send gratuities globally and participants can easily select gift cards in their currency and preference. The messaging/emails to send rewards is done via RallyUXR with our custom GitLab branding.

Unsupported Countries in Tremendous, meaning no rewards are available in the following countries: Cuba, Iran, Myanmar, North Korea, Russia, Syria, Venezuela, and Ukraine.

Check out RallyUXR's Tremendous' FAQ page or reach out in uxresearchoperations channel in Slack with any questions.

Incentives budget tracking and funding

The accounting team funds Tremendous via RallyUXR with a lump sum amount from the pre-approved research incentives budget twice a year. We issue thank you gifts from that prepaid amount. The UX Research Operations Coordinator puts through a budget request in the first month of Q1 (February) and Q3 (August) to get the funds released.

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research-coordination/shareouts/index.md

Leveraging Slack

The uxresearchreports Slack channel

A Slack channel where research publish reports.

Instructions

To share out a Research Report/Findings in our Slack channel, please follow the template flow below. You can copy the template directly into Slack for ease. We have provided examples of previous share-outs & formatting to highlight what information should be present & how to present it. If you have any questions, feel free to reach out to the team directly in the uxreops channel on Slack!

What should be posted in this channel?

All Gold level projects should be posted in this channel. Other projects (silver, bronze, etc.) are also welcome to be posted too!

Template to copy from:

text

[Include one sentence about Why & What you were researching/seeking to prove or disprove. Also link your parent research issue for people to get more details.]

Key insights:

[List your Key Insights that were derived from your research]

Key insight 1

Key insight 2

For more information:

[Include any extra links to reports, Google slides, issues, videos, raw data (if applicable), Dovetail links]

:googleslides: Report [INCLUDE LINK]

:youtube: Video readout [INCLUDE LINK]

:tanuki-heart: Research Issue [INCLUDE LINK]

Next steps:

[Try to include a next steps section to show how the research findings will be followed up. Also link any follow-up issues or discussions that may be relevant.]

Next step 1

Next step 2

Formatting

1. Bold key pieces of information or to call out particular information.

1. Separate your sections into the headings listed in the template.

1. Use bullet points within each section to break up the information so it's not just a wall of text.

1. Use emoji! Use different emoji to break up the info or to highlight different things such as:

- :googleslides: for Research Reports

- :youtube: for video readouts

- :dovetaillogo: for Dovetail links

- your choice of Tanuki for Research Issue links

1. If you have a lot of links, we recommend hiding the previews for the majority of them once you post so that the focus is on your share-out and not the pop-ups. It's fine to leave one in such as the research report which is shown in the examples.

Examples

Below are three different examples of completed Research Report Share-Out in Slack following

the above template.

Monthly share out

Each month, ReOps will select 2-3 projects from the uxresearchreports channel to broadcast in a monthly summary.

Based on how messages are presented in Slack, no more than 2-3 top projects per month should be selected and shared out in the monthly Slack post. Below is a list of what should be in the monthly share-out, where it is to be posted, an example of a full post, and the template to copy from.

What needs to be in monthly share-out?

1. Some sort of link or post to the Uxresearchreports channel to get people to join
1. 2-3 Gold Level projects
1. Tag the researchers/DRI's responsible per project
1. Follow the Key Insights structure from the Slack Research Reports Template.
1. Include Impact or next steps as listed in the above template
1. Include links that were in the original slack post (as seen in the below example).
1. Be sure to include a close-out sentence or directions for anyone who might have questions.

Where will the monthly share-out be posted?

Slack channels:

- whats-happening-at-gitlab
- uxresearch
- ux
- product

Example:

Template to copy from:

text

MONTH Edition of: :scienceparrot:All things UX Research :scienceparrot:

Include an introduction sentence and a call-out to join the uxresearchreports channel.

:party-gitlab: STAGE GROUP - Pick out a key insight and bold it. Link to the Parent research issue. (The link should be the entire sentence to make it stand out.)

List & tag the who (Researcher/DRI) and what/why they were carrying out their research for.

Key insights:

[List the Key Insights that were listed in the original post]

Key insight 1

Key insight 2

For more information:

[Include the links which were provided in the original post]

:googleslides: Report [INCLUDE LINK]

:youtube: Video readout [INCLUDE LINK]

:tanuki-heart: Research Issue [INCLUDE LINK]

Next steps:

[List any next steps from the original post]

Next step 1

Next step 2

Include a close-out sentence at the end of your post or instructions for any questions.

SECTION: product/ux/ux-resources/_index.md

This page includes information about UX Resources to help you do your job. It is not intended to be an all-inclusive list or to limit the methodologies or approaches you might take in your daily work. If you believe that something useful is missing, please submit an MR!

UX team workflows

- Product Designer workflows
- UX Researcher workflows
- Technical Writing workflows

UX Department Google Calendar

We use the shared UX Department Google Calendar (link is only available to GitLab employees) to advertise upcoming meetings and events. Anyone in the UX Department can add events to this calendar but only managers can make changes to events and manage sharing. These invites are only viewable by GitLab employees.

To add the UX Department Calendar to your list of calendars:

1. Go to your calendar
1. Scroll the left sidebar down to Other calendars
1. Press on +
1. Select Subscribe to calendar
1. Enter in the search field gitlab.com9psh26fha3e4mvhlrefusb619k@group.calendar.google.com and then press enter on your keyboard

NOTE: Please do NOT remove any meetings from this calendar or any other shared calendars, as it removes the event from everyone's calendar.

Design resources

The following resources are intended primarily to help Product Designers.

GitLab Design project

The GitLab design project is primarily used by the Product Design team to document workflows and processes. For details, please visit the project README.

- View the project

YouTube Channels

- UX Team
- UX Scorecards
- UX Forum
- GitLab Design Talks - Iteration
- GitLab Design Talks - Collaboration
- GitLab Design Talks - Design Leadership & Career Development

Pajamas Design System

The GitLab Design System, Pajamas, was developed to increase iteration speed and bring consistency to the UI through reusable and robust components. This system helps keep the application DRY and allows designers to focus their efforts on solving user needs, rather than recreating elements and reinventing solutions. It also empowers Product, Engineering, and the Community to use these defined patterns when proposing solutions.

- Visit design.gitlab.com
- View the Pajamas UI Kit on Figma
- View the project
- View dev object model (video)

SVGs

Our SVG repository manages all GitLab SVG assets by creating an SVG sprite out of icons and optimizing SVG-based illustrations.

- SVG Previewer
- View the project

Jobs to be Done (JTBD)

We use the JTBD framework for viewing products and solutions in terms of the jobs customers are trying to achieve. It's about understanding the goals that people want to accomplish. JTBD is used throughout the design process to determine scope, validate direction, evaluate existing experiences with UX Scorecards, and assess our Category Maturity with Category Maturity

Scorecards.

- JTBD Overview
- JTBD Deep Dive
- Mapping JTBD

Design Reviews

View how we collect synchronous and asynchronous design feedback.

Design Studios

Design Studios are regular meetings for product designers to connect and work together. They provide casual time for socializing, sharing work, getting feedback, and more.

Tools

Figma We use Figma for designing and prototyping. Our Pajamas UI kit contains design assets, components, and styles for GitLab's design system, Pajamas. Additionally, there is a Figma plugin available that allows designers to upload design files directly into a GitLab issue. Every product designer should receive access to Figma during onboarding. If you don't have the access you need, reach out to your manager. If you are not a product designer but want View access (including the ability to leave comments), create a free Figma account and ask your stage group designer for a link to the relevant files.

Figma admins and their role scope are defined as:

Admin	Scope
-----	-----
@tauriedavis	Tech stack owner, user management (Provisioning/deprovisioning), billing
@vkarnes	Tech stack owner fall back
@jeldergl	User management (Provisioning/deprovisioning), design ops
@danmh	Design ops

Figjam We use Figjam for collecting design feedback, mapping workflows, brainstorming, affinity mapping, and anything else where we need a visual, whiteboard-like workspace.

Everyone in the UX department and all Product Managers can get a Figma account with the ability to create new Figjam boards. If you want to share your Figjam board to get feedback from members of your team who do not have a Figma account, you can send an anonymous link via the Share dialog.

Dovetail We use Dovetail to manage and analyze research findings. If you need access, please submit an Access Request.

Gong is a conversation intelligence tool to record sales facing conversations and provide analytics and insights into those conversations. It can help UX team members identify customers to speak with, or search calls for topics of interest. It is available to UX team members upon request. Create an access request if you would like to use it. You can request the "Collaborator" role.

Highspot contains information about Go-to-market including sales enablement and competitor research. Highspot can be accessed through SSO and is available upon request. Create an access request if you would like to use it. For more information, see the Highspot handbook page

Tutorials

The UX team is encouraged to make improvements directly in the product when they find something that is small and easy to change.

- Technical Tutorials for Product Designers - video playlist for best practices on technical topics
- How to do UI Code Contributions
- Step by Step Guide to Make Code Changes
- Using data for design decisions
- Implementing frontend click tracking for designers

Prototypes

Coming soon.

Research resources

The following resources may be helpful to UX Researchers, Product Designers, and Product Managers, since all of these roles conduct user research. For more information, see the UX Research section of the handbook.

UX Research project

The UX Research project contains all research undertaken by GitLab's UX researchers and is only used for the organization and tracking of UX research issues.

- View the project

System Usability Scale

Once each quarter, we run a System Usability Scale (SUS) survey to measure user perception of the GitLab product. We send the survey to members of the wider GitLab community, with the goal of asking for a response from any individual no more than once per year.

- SUS results by quarter

UX performance indicators

We track our effectiveness through UX performance indicators (PIs). Our e-group reviews these PIs once a month in the Engineering Key Review.

User personas

User personas represent the people who actually use GitLab. The UX and Marketing teams use personas to inform decisions around the user experience and design.

- View our user personas

From the GitLab team

Not only do our team members create great work for the wider GitLab community, but they also create some amazing industry-related resources to push our craft forward.

- Building Design Systems: Unify User Experiences through a Shared Design Language, by Taurie Davis and Sarrah Vesselov
- Craft Awesome Web Typography, by Matej Latin
- Hemingway - Figma plugin, by Michael Le
- GitLab-ipsu, by Patrick Deuley and Jeremy Elder

SECTION: product/ux/ux-resources/dark-mode-rollout-playbook.md

This playbook is a step-by-step plan for product teams to directly support the rollout and implementation of dark mode in their areas of responsibility. While dark mode has been integrated into the design system, there are potential gaps and custom implementations that need to be reviewed before we can transition dark mode from Experimental (alpha) to Beta status.

Once dark mode reaches Beta, it will require formal support in line with our feature maturity guidelines. Product teams will ultimately be responsible for ensuring their areas deliver a consistent and cohesive dark mode experience aligned with the design system.

By following this playbook, teams will not only contribute to a high-quality dark mode experience today but also build the expertise needed to maintain and enhance it and other modes in the future.

Getting started

Begin by familiarizing yourself with the following definitions and concepts. Dark mode will be the most successful when the implementation is based on a correct and consistent use of color design tokens, Pajamas design system components, and concepts like design principles for color use. The goal is not only to be able to spot when something is incorrect or missing, but also to know how and when to design and implement bespoke solutions in your own product area.

Dark mode

Dark mode has become an essential user interface (UI) design feature, providing a darker background with lighter content to reduce eye strain, enhance readability, and maintain continuity with system-wide settings. Read our blog post that introduces our dark mode vision.

Design tokens

Design tokens are a methodology to pair design decisions with options from the design system. For the dark mode rollout, the focus is on semantic design tokens. Specifically, semantic color design tokens that reference constant color design tokens to express design decisions. This

makes them particularly valuable because they:

- Reference constant design tokens to define global design decisions for elements like text, icons, borders, and surfaces.
- Use a naming strategy that communicates design intent and proper usage, rather than specific values, creating an abstraction layer between raw values and their implementation.
- Contain values for both light and dark mode, so they maintain consistent meaning when adapting properties across different contexts.

This semantic approach helps ensure design decisions are applied consistently in any mode while preserving their intended purpose, regardless of the specific visual values being used.

Pajamas design system

Pajamas is GitLab's design system that provides standardized components (with mode-changing capabilities included), patterns, and guidelines for building consistent user interfaces across the GitLab product. It includes detailed specifications for elements like typography, color, spacing, and interactive components, enabling designers and developers to create cohesive product experiences while reducing design complexity.

Dark mode preference in GitLab

After authenticating, turn on the dark mode experience by navigating to <https://gitlab.com/-/profile/preferences>. Under the Appearance heading choose either Dark (Experiment) or Auto (Experiment) if you're using dark mode as your system setting.

Getting help

The Design System Group is available to help and can be reached by mention in the product, or in the `gpajamas-design-system` Slack channel.

Evaluation

The core objective of evaluating product pages is twofold:

Primary goal: Ensure your most-used pages are properly configured for dark mode and can smoothly adapt to future theme changes with minimal intervention. This requires examining both the visual design choices and their technical implementation.

Secondary goal: Build your understanding of theming concepts, enabling you to make informed design and implementation decisions that align with our design system.

When we achieve these goals, we'll see several benefits:

- A more cohesive, consistent product experience.
- Seamless propagation of design system updates.
- Confidence to move dark mode beyond beta to general availability.

During your evaluation, you'll likely discover additional opportunities for improvement beyond what impacts dark mode. While some changes may not be immediately visible to users, they can

enhance accessibility, improve component and design system compliance, and help us identify areas where the design system needs expansion or where guidance is needed for custom solutions.

Tools

In addition to your day-to-day tools like Chrome, Figma, GDK, GitLab Duo, and others, the following will be especially helpful and are featured predominantly in the steps below. Note that at any point you can use tools or methods that you or your team are more familiar with, however the outcome should be the same.

- Hot pink bookmarklet: A browser bookmarklet that finds all color-related CSS variables defined at the root level (except those starting with "--gl") and changes them to hotpink to easily visualize elements that aren't using design tokens.
- Highlighter Chrome extension: A Chrome extension that highlights UI elements matching a specified CSS class, class prefix, or class suffix. When activated, it outlines matching elements in red (color can be customized) to make them easily visible on the page.
- Claude AI: An AI assistant that is used to help inspect code by using different prompts.
- Vue.js devtools browser extension: Easily inspect Vue components and open them directly in your favorite IDE (e.g. VSCode) with a single click on a button to speed up finding the corresponding files.

Steps

As a prerequisite, create an epic that includes a description with a list of the most-used or important pages and their alternate UI states in your area of the product (examples in the reference section below). This list will be used for all steps by all roles. Include links, instructions, and configuration requirements needed to access the pages and UI in the product or GDK. Starting with an epic will be helpful so you can track individual issues for your findings later.

There are templates for both Figma and FigJam that you can duplicate and use to annotate screenshots. If you don't have access to Figma, use the Design Management feature in GitLab to upload and annotate screenshots.

1. Visual review

Who: Product designers and frontend engineers

Outcome: Identify parts of the UI that visibly aren't using design tokens for color and when applicable, suggest remedies.

1. With the hot pink bookmarklet enabled in your browser, view a page from your list. You'll need to refresh any open pages for the bookmarklet to take effect, but you won't have to for future page loads.
2. Take screenshots of the page. Be sure to expose hidden elements like dropdowns, tooltips, collapsed containers, and error states. Depending on the page, you may also need to test a variety of conditions, like empty vs. populated regions and responsive layout changes. It can be helpful to capture a screenshot both with and without the hot pink highlights to compare the actual appearance with the findings.
UI without and with hot pink highlights
3. Annotate your screenshots in Figma, FigJam, or a GitLab issue by marking elements as related to one of the following categories (examples can be seen in the Figma and FigJam files):

1. Ideas for existing Pajamas solutions that specifically relate to dark mode. These annotations should suggest using a semantic color design token instead of hard-coded colors or constants, or they can suggest using a different design token than the one currently applied to better align semantics and intent.
2. Discussions to have about bespoke dark mode or design system solutions. This includes parts of the UI where none of the existing design tokens are a good fit and something new may be needed. It could also include discussions about replacing a custom solution with an existing Pajamas component.
3. Notes for others, for example, candidate for design system team solution or a paper cut to fix. Make a note of items you encounter that can be fixed upstream in the design system or where minor refactoring could make the dark mode implementation more seamless.

Annotated screenshot in Figma

4. Under the epic, create an issue for each finding.

Common findings:

- Icons that are using text design tokens instead of ones specifically for icons.
- Elements that are using hard-coded or color constants instead of a semantic design token.
- Custom elements that don't fit into any of the current semantic design token categories like status, feedback, or action.
- Elements with style overrides that impact the visual presentation.
- Color contrast issues where the contrast is lower than 4.5:1 for text or 3:1 for graphic elements.

2. Element inspection

Who: Product designers and frontend engineers

Outcome: Identify common elements (for example, text, icons, and borders) that aren't using design tokens correctly in code and provide remedies.

1. Familiarize yourself with the different elements on the page along with how they're being used. Using developer tools, inspect elements to make sure that the visual presentation matches the purpose and intent. For example:
 1. If an icon is present, is it being used for status, help, feedback, a static visual element, or something else? The design token used should match the design intent.
 2. Is a border being used as a divider or to surround a container? Does it match expected combinations? (See this merge request that adds more clarity for border and background use.)
 3. Something looks like a component, but is it? If so, is it being used correctly? If not, could it be migrated to one?
2. With the Highlighter extension enabled, enter a class name, prefix, or suffix to highlight matching elements.

Highlighter extension and highlighted element

 Keep in mind that what isn't highlighted can be just as important as what is and can indicate things that appear as one thing, but are really something else. It's likely that elements like this won't respond as expected to mode changes or adhere to future design changes. Because of the cascading part of CSS, not everything will be highlighted as expected and developer tools will still be helpful to determine computed styles. Example queries:
 1. Enter "gl-link" to highlight all links.
 2. Enter "gl-form-" to ensure that all elements that appear to be a form element really are.
 3. Enter "gl-text-" to see if any icons happen to be using text styles.
3. Copy and paste the page source into Claude and run prompts against it. Example prompts:

1. List out all elements that use a CSS class that doesn't include ".gl-".
2. Are there any SVGs elements nested under elements with a class beginning with "gl-text-"?
4. Add annotations to the screenshots from the visual review for items not previously noted.
5. Under the epic, create an issue for each new finding.

Common findings:

- Icons that are using text design tokens instead of ones specifically for icons.
- Background and border design token pairing that doesn't match expected combinations.
- Headings that aren't using a heading design token or non-heading text that does.
- Elements that appear to be a component, but aren't.
- Elements that are a component, but have overrides that cause them to not appear as expected.

3. Code review

Who: Engineers

Outcome: Identify components that need migration, things that aren't a component but should be, and things that use a component incorrectly or have unsustainable overrides.

1. Review the codebase structure and component usage for the page:
 1. Check if components are imported from the Pajamas design system (@gitlab/ui) or if they're custom implementations.
 2. Identify any legacy components that have Pajamas equivalents and should be migrated.
2. Use developer tools and automated analysis to inspect component implementation:
 1. Check for components with extensive CSS overrides that might indicate a misuse or gap in the design system.
 2. Look for nested components that could cause theme inheritance issues.
 3. Verify that components are receiving proper props and using the design system's theme context correctly.
3. Use Claude or GitLab Duo to analyze the codebase with prompts like:
 1. Find components with more than 3 levels of CSS class overrides.
 2. Find components or SVGs using direct color values (hex codes, rgb, etc.) instead of design tokens that support dark mode.
 3. Find instances where components are nested inside other components in ways that could break dark mode inheritance.
4. Add annotations to the screenshots from the visual review for items not previously noted.
5. Under the epic, create an issue for each new finding.

Common findings:

- Legacy components with direct Pajamas equivalents that haven't been migrated.
- Components with extensive overrides that should be reconsidered.
- Nested components causing unexpected theme inheritance.
- Components using hard-coded color values instead of design tokens.

Additional findings

As mentioned before, while going through this process, you're likely to uncover other opportunities to improve accessibility, design system compliance, and identify gaps where the design system needs to expand or provide more guidance. These findings can also be captured

with the rest of the annotations. The UX Paper Cuts Group is a great resource to help resolve these items too. Here are some additional things to look for along with related AI prompts:

- Find headings that are out of order or missing: List headings in order and include their level.
- Identify inaccessible form elements: List form elements that have missing or problematic labels.
- Find instances to use Pajamas components: List custom components that implement similar functionality to existing Pajamas components.
- Look for opportunities to abstract patterns: Identify repeated style patterns that could be abstracted into a shared component.

Addressing findings

If you've familiarized yourself with the the getting started content and references, prioritized your pages, and have completed creating issues for each finding, you're well on your way to addressing those findings.

- Use existing Pajamas solutions when they're available. Refer to our Design token documentation in Pajamas for guidance on choosing the right tokens.
- Engage in discussions when you have custom parts of the UI that existing solutions don't apply to or when you're not sure how or if you can migrate to an existing design system solution.
- Help with upstream fixes in the design system or simple paper cut fixes that unblock dark mode from taking effect in your product area.

If at any point you get stuck or need a second opinion or review, reach out to the Design System or UX Paper Cuts groups.

Reference

- Dark mode > Rollout by stage group
- Example evaluations: Knowledge, Source Code, Pipeline Execution, Import & Integrate

SECTION: product/ux/ux-resources/designers-guide-to-data.md

Using data for design decisions at GitLab

Data is another way designers and researchers at GitLab can understand user behavior. Analytics can provide valuable input throughout the Product Development Flow. By using data, we can understand and quantify the impact of the iteration that we shipped.

We should not depend entirely on data to make decisions, but it should be an essential input to decision making. To learn more about quantitative data/research, see the Using Data to Find Insights handbook page.

{{< youtube "J-USG9BKH-g" >}}

Aligning hypothesis to impact

Part of the design process is to have a strong hypothesis to guide our work.

Ideally, the hypothesis will be based on information from user research.

For example:

> We believe storing information about how an incident was resolved, how long the resolution took, and what the outcome was in a way that's easy for engineers responsible for incident management to access will achieve a 20% faster resolution time for incidents.

Here are possible ways one could use data to understand whether a 20% faster resolution time for incidents was achieved or not:

- Measure time between two steps in the user journey
- Measure the total time spent for resolution
- Conduct an A/B test to compare the two solutions

These data points would be hard to obtain during solution validation but when measured they help connect the dots from research, iteration, to impact.

By observing and measuring, it should spark further questions to help generate more possible iterations in the future.

How is data being captured

To generate reports and dashboards, we use a third party tool called Tableau to visualize the data captured.

The data source determines the table names used in Tableau queries. We have three primary data sources that are useful from a product perspective: service ping, product database, and internal events.

Our goal is to analyze product usage. NOT to track individual users. This means on the frontend we respect browser settings of "do not track" and allow opting out of usage ping. In addition to that, the Analytics Instrumentation team is responsible for data pseudonymization so that there no personally identifiable information saved. This video highlights how Snowplow, usage ping, and pseudonymization work together.

Overview of the data sources

- Service Ping (for Self-Managed and GitLab.com)
 - A custom GitLab tool to collect aggregate information from our customers who host our product on their own hardware.
- Video: Usage Ping Workshop
- Examples of when to use:
 - Total number of issues
 - Count of distinct users creating issues
 - Instance settings - Git version, database version

- Count of feature enabled
- Count of created notes on Snippets
- Count of notes on Merge Request
- GitLab.com Postgres Database (for GitLab.com)
- Internal Events (for GitLab.com)
 - Captures client/server side events and page views
 - Tools for viewing events for exploration/testing
 - Implementing event tracking
- deprecated Snowplow (for GitLab.com)
 - Captures client/server side events and page views
 - Video: Snowplow 2.0 Workshop
 - Tools for viewing events for exploration/testing
 - Implementing Snowplow click tracking for designers

Key Data Sources for Product Managers at GitLab elaborates on how each data source is used and queried.

These visualizations will help you understand how the systems work together:

- A simplified diagram showing the interactions between GitLab Inc and self-managed instances.
- A detailed diagram of the data platform's data stack.

Examples of using data for design decisions

The issues and merge requests below are examples of how we have used data for decisions.

- Adds snowplow-based event tracking to see how often users are expanding the unit test report MR widget
- Left sidebar and top nav navigation interaction (internal link)
- How many users are setup to approve more than one rule (internal link)
- Choosing between a textarea and an input
- Standardizing device width in designs

Frequently asked questions

- Who can I ask for data help? If you have any specific questions around Data or Tableau, you can connect with them on Slack in data.
- What happens when there is no baseline metric to measure from? When there is no baseline, use the data that is to be tracked as the baseline after a month of data.

Resources

- Data for Product Managers
- Internal Analytics at GitLab
- Experimentation Design & Analysis
- Growth Experiments Knowledge Base
- Using Data to Find Insights

SECTION: product/ux/ux-resources/designers-step-by-step-guide-to-make-code-changes.md

What is this?

This is a step-by-step guide for how to make code changes against the main GitLab codebase. This guide is meant to serve as a follow-along tutorial for anyone with semi-technical knowledge who wants to contribute to GitLab by making small UI changes (like text changes). These changes are meaningful contributions that work towards the consistency of GitLab's UI.

These changes are an excellent way to add value to the GitLab project and can be good starter MRs for anyone who wants to get familiar with the GitLab codebase and do more meaningful changes in the future.

This guide is based on this video tutorial by @jj-ramirez.

Pre-requisites

Before you start with this guide, make sure you have the GDK installed and running. You can follow the GDK installation and setup steps in the following pages:

- Learn how to prepare your workstation to run GDK
- Learn how to install GDK
- Learn how to run GDK
- GDK Commands cheatsheet

Note: After installing your GDK you should have a gitlab-development-kit folder (that's the default name, but it can be different if you changed the name in the installation process). Inside of it you should have a working gitlab folder that contains all the files of the GitLab project. Both folders should be available and browseable if you installed your GDK correctly.

You also need to have Visual Studio Code installed since this is the code editor that we would be using for this tutorial. You can download the latest version of Visual Studio Code in the following page:

- Visual Studio Code

Finally, you need to have your Git and SSH credentials correctly set up in your machine. If you haven't configured SSH access in your computer you can do so by completing the configuration explained in the following tutorial:

- Setting up SSH access

Step by step guide

1. Open the gitlab folder from your Visual Studio Code. You can do that by going to File > Open... and by locating your gitlab folder inside the gitlab-development-kit or equivalent GDK directory.

1. Open your Terminal. A terminal or CLI it's available in all major operating systems. This guide was prepared on MacOS so we will be using Terminal for all the examples. You can find the MacOS Terminal in the Applications folder.

1. Navigate to your gitlab folder in the Terminal. You can do this by using the `cd` command to drill into folders. One simple way to quickly jump into the gitlab folder is to locate it in a Finder window and drag and drop it on the Terminal. This would provide the absolute path to where your gitlab folder is located.

To do this simply type `cd` in your Terminal. Locate the gitlab folder in a Finder window and drag and drop it on the Terminal. The resulting command would look something like this `cd /Users/jj-gitlab/Desktop/GDK/gdk2/gitlab`. Hit Enter and you should be inside the right folder. You can make sure that's the case by checking that the name of the folder shows up next to the name of your machine in the Terminal.

1. Start your GDK by running the `gdk start` command. This will spin a local version of GitLab that is available at the test host you setup when installing your GDK or more generally at your localhost: <https://127.0.0.1:3000/>

1. If everything is working well you should be able to see a login page for a GitLab instance in your browser. Log in using the GDK credentials. You can find the GDK credentials by typing `gdk help` in the terminal. The credentials can be found at the bottom of the resulting message.

1. Prepare your Git so you can start pushing changes once you're ready. The first thing you want to do is to create and switch to a new branch. You can do that by typing the following command in your terminal: `git switch -c "your-branch-name"`. For your branch name make sure to pick a meaningful and short name. Branch names should use kebab/hyphenated case ('a-branch-name').

1. Once you're checked out into a new branch is time to start exploring some potential changes. This guide mostly focuses on UI text changes so we will use an example of that nature for the rest of the guide. In this guide, we will be changing a text found in the general settings, specifically in the "Naming, Topics, Avatar" section.

The text is Update your project name, topics, description and avatar.. We will change that text to Update your project name, topics, description, compliance framework, and avatar. Have in mind that this is just an example for the tutorial and no actual change will be pushed permanently.

Make sure to check for the existence of this particular text in your GDK-powered environment. Do so by going to one of the sample projects and clicking on Settings and then in General. The helper text of the first section is what we will be changing.

1. Now that we have a clear goal of what we are changing is time to find the file or files that need to be modified for this change to happen. To do this go to Visual Studio Code and click on the Global Search icon on the left sidebar of your Visual Studio Code window. This should reveal a text box where you can type your search query. In this particular case, we are searching for a particular string which is Update your project name, topics, description and avatar. Simply copy and paste that line in the search box.

At this point, you should see some search results that match your query. Since this guide is focused on making UI string changes here are some general rules to make sure that you're indeed changing the correct occurrence of that text:

- Don't change any `gitlab.pot` file. Those are translation files that are created and updated by a job that you will be running later in this guide.

- Your strings could be located in either a .haml (server template) file or .vue (frontend component) file. Regardless of which files are being changed the most likely scenario is that your targeted string is wrapped inside markdown that looks like this ('string') or like this s('string'). In this example, the text we are looking for should look like this: ('Update your project name, topics, description and avatar.')

- Your search query could show up in test files. Test files end in .spec.rb or .spec.js. If your string matches a test file, it's likely that the test file needs to be changed. If those test files aren't modified your pipeline will fail when you push the changes. This will be explained better later in the Caveats section of this guide.

1. Now that we have some rules of how to modify UI strings, is time to make the actual change. Before this step we searched for Update your project name, topics, description and avatar. This should return a match inside a file named edit.html.haml. This file